Traditional Chinese Medicine at Tong Keow Healthcare

Everyday care, convenience, localisation, and pattern differentiation

GEC1044 Group Fieldwork Report • Revised complete draft

TD3 Group 2
Lou Yu Luke · Chang Tze Yi Othniel · Li Xudong
Curtis Chang Kai Xian · Hu Zhixuan Shirley
Tutor Lin Shi Ting

Field visit 13 September 2026
Block 809 Hougang Central #01-170 Singapore 530809
Revised 4 October 2026

Revision note

This revision keeps the central argument focused on how Tong Keow fits traditional materials into household practices. Course connections are concentrated in four analytical passages, while the workplace-stress discussion and conclusion explain the findings' significance more fully. Staff accounts, photographs and interpretations remain distinct. The seven survey records stay in Appendix A, and industry sources retain their stated status.

1 Introduction

At Tong Keow's Hougang outlet, herbs and packaged soups sit alongside grains and everyday foods. Staff described purchases for nourishment, throat comfort, fatigue and concerns about daily routines. These shelves and accounts place Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM) within ordinary shopping and cooking, the starting point of our report.

We argue that Tong Keow helps sustain TCM by fitting traditional materials into everyday household practices. Section 3 explains how food use gives herbs a familiar purpose. Section 4 examines how prepared products reduce the work of using them. Section 5 considers their fit with Singapore's production, regulation and cultural setting. Section 6 brings these connections together and explains the role of individual assessment in treatment. Appendix A retains the detailed survey findings.

2 Fieldwork and the neighbourhood medicine hall

2.1 How we conducted the fieldwork

We visited Tong Keow on 13 September 2026, photographed the displays and interviewed one staff member. This report draws on the transcripts, presentation script and photographs. We paraphrase clear statements where transcription errors occur. Staff accounts refer to this interview (Tong Keow staff member, personal communication, September 13, 2026).

Staff descriptions refer to the interview; descriptions of displays refer to our photographs. We identify our interpretations when explaining their significance. Published sources provide historical

and industry context, while course concepts guide our reflection. Accounts of popular and lower-demand products represent the staff member's retail experience.

2.2 Tong Keow and its mixed retail model

The presentation traces Tong Keow's Toa Payoh shop to 1968, consistent with a directory's account of its fiftieth anniversary in 2018. Business registration came later: Tong Keow Medicine and Provision Shop on 29 March 1975, and Tong Keow Medical Hall Pte. Ltd. on 1 January 2015. Both list 70 Lorong 4 Toa Payoh #01-333, Toa Payoh Vista. Their classifications cover Chinese medicine shops and provision or convenience stores (codes 47723 and 47102), matching the medicinal and food range observed (Accounting and Corporate Regulatory Authority [ACRA], n.d.; Healthcare.com.sg, n.d.; Singapore Department of Statistics [DOS], n.d.).

The tutor described Tong Keow as a chain, and the directory links its Toa Payoh and Hougang outlets. Our photographs show branded soup packs alongside herbs, grains and other foods. The branding connects the branch to the wider business. We interpret the mixed range as central to its everyday role: herbal goods can be encountered during an ordinary food-shopping trip.

2.3 Hougang and the customers described by staff

Staff described customers as mainly Chinese, middle-aged and older, including people in their forties and fifties. Hougang planning area had 228,140 residents in June 2024. HDB separately reported 57,557 dwelling units and 165,450 residents in its Hougang flats at 31 March 2024. These totals cover different housing populations (DOS, 2024; Housing & Development Board [HDB], 2024, pp. 11–12).

Hougang Central, the subzone around the outlet, had about 4,620 residents in June 2025. Official rounded age-band totals put around 1,070 residents at age 65 or above, roughly 23% (DOS, 2025). This substantial older population provides a local setting for the clientele described by staff and for interpreting the shop's household foods and nourishment products.

Chua et al.'s (2025) 647 Hougang respondents averaged 69 years of age and 22 years of residence. Seventeen per cent lived alone, compared with 15% of 552 Taman Jurong respondents; the difference was not statistically significant. The long residence is especially relevant here: it places the medicine hall within an established community where household shopping and care take place.

Hougang's Teochew history adds another dimension. The National Heritage Board records the community around Tou Mu Kung and its fishing, farming and rubber-growing activities (National Heritage Board [NHB], n.d.). We interpret this history and residential setting as context for the shop's mixed medicinal and food range. Staff supplied the account of its current customers.

3 Everyday care and food therapy

3.1 Herbs in household meals

Staff named Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates and goji as common soup ingredients. The presentation included ginseng/American ginseng and monk fruit among its eight

herb entries. Table A1 separates the ginseng profiles. Prepared packs and a family cooking image place these materials in the setting of a household meal (Figures 1–2).

Soup gives herbs a familiar household purpose. Lecture 5 describes Chinese medicine as a cultural framework that enters everyday food and health habits. This helps us interpret the display through nourishing life, 养生, and medicine and food sharing a source, 药食同源. Lim et al. (2005) identify health maintenance as a significant reason for use, while Yang (2022) situates medicine in changing community life. The fieldwork gives this idea a concrete form: herbal materials enter the household through cooking.

3.2 Soup packs and light nourishment

The presentation grouped soups under five labels: Qing Bu Liang 清补凉, Dang Shen–Huang Qi soup 党参北芪补气汤, Yu Zhu–Huai Shan soup 玉竹淮山润燥汤, goji–red date soup 枸杞红枣养生汤 and Five Finger Fig soup 五指毛桃健脾汤. Table A4 records their named ingredients and connects familiar preparations to specific forms of care.

Staff associated these soups with digestion, moistening and light nourishment, 清补. Light replenishment offers an everyday approach alongside stronger tonification, 大补. Named packs make this vocabulary practical: buyers can take a preparation home to cook. In the context of these pre-selected soup packs, the Spleen and Liver do not merely represent anatomical structures, but specify broader TCM functional systems that dictate how light nourishment formulations support digestion and metabolic balance (World Health Organization [WHO], 2022). We interpret the packs as bringing these ideas into meals.

3.3 Singapore weather and the appeal of lighter soups

Staff linked monk fruit's popularity and lighter soups to Singapore's environment. Meteorological Service Singapore describes high temperatures, abundant rainfall and humidity throughout the year, with monsoon and inter-monsoon periods (Meteorological Service Singapore [MSS], n.d.). This gives climatic context to the presentation's phrase "without four distinct seasons" and the staff account of local demand.

The Suwen (素问) reading relates seasonal habits to maintaining health (Unschuld & Tessenow, 2011, pp. 45–57). We interpret the staff's discussion of lighter soups as environmental reasoning expressed in retail advice. Singapore's weather supplies a local context for explaining their appeal. The ingredient profiles make this account more specific: Yu Zhu （玉竹）, for example, is associated with moistening dryness. Climate provides context for the staff account, while the named ingredients retain their particular TCM functions.

4 Convenience and changing consumption forms

4.1 Easier preparation for the convenience of younger buyers

Staff described younger customers as buying fewer raw herbs and preferring teas, supplements and simpler preparations. Table A2 retains eight presentation categories, including ginseng tonics, herbal teas, soup packs, mood-support products and medicated oils. This account directs attention to product form: staff associate easier preparation with younger customers' routines.

Soup packs make this demand for convenience visible. Because ingredients are pre-selected and portioned, households can bypass raw processing and begin directly with cooking. While staff explain the intended use of specific ingredients, buyers complete the final preparation at home. Finished capsules require even less effort, whereas the photographed multi-buy promotion frames soup packs through a familiar supermarket retail offer. Ultimately, we interpret convenience as a structural redistribution of labor between the seller and the household, making traditional materials significantly easier to choose and incorporate into modern routines.

4.2 Comparative industry examples

Industry comparisons describe deliberate changes in how herbal goods are offered. Nanyang Polytechnic discusses Heng Foh Tong's herbal-drink redesign for millennials (Nanyang Polytechnic [NYP], n.d.). Amacha markets TCM-inspired milk teas; a founder interview reported over 150,000 cups sold in eight months (Amacha, n.d.; Angelynn T., 2026). Teck Soon's owner reported a 30% sales increase after moving herbs from drawers to storefront displays in 1982 (Chin, 2024). These are promotional, journalistic or institutional public-relations accounts, not peer-reviewed studies. Their value lies in the specific strategies described: changing product forms and making herbs easier to encounter. They give context to Tong Keow's prepared packs and staff account of convenience.

4.3 Products for daily pressures

Staff associate modern daily pressures, such as late nights, long work hours and prolonged phone use, with demand for liver-care or mood-support products. This commercial alignment is exemplified by remedies designed for soothing Liver-related constraint (疏肝解郁), effectively bridging traditional therapeutic vocabulary with contemporary lifestyle ailments.

A comparative survey places this retail language in a wider setting. Reporting on ADP's 2023 survey, Kumari (2024) reports that 68% of Singapore workers experience work-related stress at least weekly, compared with 61% in the surveyed Asia-Pacific markets; 12% reported daily stress. This survey provides context for the staff's descriptions of strain. We interpret the shop's product language as making TCM relevant to familiar pressures and daily routines, supporting our argument that traditional goods acquire new everyday uses through adaptation.

4.4 Preparation complexity and lower-demand products

Lower-demand examples further explain the appeal of simpler formats. The presentation listed three staff-described lower-demand examples: Ban Zhi Lian (半枝莲), specialist herbs requiring combinations, and strong tonic formulas (大补方) (Table A5). Staff linked their lower appeal to

unfamiliarity and preparation effort; the presentation also discussed the suitability of stronger tonic formulas in Singapore's climate. Staff said slower-moving items were stocked in smaller quantities. We interpret these accounts as linking a product's shelf presence and stock quantity to the explanation and preparation it requires. This helps explain the appeal of prepared packs, which shift selection and portioning to the shop.

5 Localisation through products packaging and cultural contact

5.1 Imported materials and locally made products

Lecture 5 treats localisation as adaptation to climate, available materials and society. At Tong Keow, it appears at several production stages. Staff described imports mainly from China, citing variety and cost, with limited local cultivation. The presentation retained cactus 仙人掌, roselle 洛神花, patent medicines 中成药, Five Flower Tea 五花茶 and monk-fruit tea 罗汉果茶 (Table A3).

Branded packs also give herbs a recognisable retail form. Staff described local processing and packing. Our interpretation centres on the visible selection and portioning of ingredients, named uses and local branding. Packaging actively shapes the product encountered by shoppers. Table A3 distinguishes cultivation, manufacture and packaging to clarify each example's connection to Singapore.

Local manufacture and assembly of finished Chinese Proprietary Medicines (CPM) occupy a formal place in Singapore's supply chain. The Health Sciences Authority (HSA) requires relevant dealer licences and product listing, with facilities subject to licensing and Good Manufacturing Practice requirements (HSA, 2026c, 2026d). The capsule example connects the shelf to this framework. Raw herbs, foods and soup packs have their respective product categories.

5.2 Packaging and the language of trust

Packaging identifies a product's contents and source. HSA's CPM guidelines require full English labelling, corresponding information in additional languages, and product and ingredient details. Batch, expiry and relevant manufacturer, importer or assembler information are also required (HSA, 2025a, section 5). These requirements shape the box shoppers encounter. Product listing is separate from an assessment of therapeutic efficacy (HSA, 2026b), a distinction that matters when reading health claims.

Quality labels offer another form of communication. Staff emphasised fresh colour and sulphur-free materials; our photograph shows a sulphur-free Dang Shen label and a separate American ginseng label (Figure 3). We interpret these claims about quality and identity as invitations to trust the shop's goods. HSA cautions against treating "natural" as a safety guarantee (HSA, 2026a), a necessary limit on that reading. These practices will attract younger customers by reassuring them about product quality and addressing their concerns about potential side effects.

5.3 Different shoppers in a shared space

At Tong Keow, staff reported that most customers were Chinese, but Malay customers came to buy dessert ingredients and Indian customers came to buy nuts. These everyday food purchases give

different communities familiar reasons to enter the same medicine hall. Eu Yan Sang offers a useful comparison: its halal product category shows how a business can meet different consumers' needs (Eu Yan Sang, n.d.). The Tong Keow account illustrates a different route to reaching different communities: ordinary food shopping.

Lecture 5's discussion of senna is helpful here. It shows that the same plant can carry different meanings in Chinese and Malay medicine. The same logic can be applied to Tong Keow's shared shopping space: customers may encounter the same goods through different habits and purposes. We therefore read the staff's account of dessert ingredients and nuts as cultural contact through ordinary purchases. The shop can become familiar to different communities while allowing those communities to understand its products differently. This connects the course discussion to a retail setting, where the field evidence lies in everyday shopping routines.

6 Bringing the findings together: pattern differentiation and adaptation

6.1 Retail advice and pattern differentiation

Table A1 describes ginseng as neutral and American ginseng as cool and Yin-nourishing. These contrasting profiles clarify the importance of individualised assessment. The staff's pairing of fatigue with tonic use in Table A6 offers a starting point for discussion, but choosing between them clinically requires a fuller assessment of signs and symptoms through pattern differentiation and treatment (辨证论治) (WHO, 2022). This echoes Lecture 5's contrast between treatment approaches for cold-damage and warm-disease patterns. The ginseng comparison makes this principle tangible: the appropriate choice depends on the person's fuller clinical presentation.

These clinical distinctions also need to be understood within a broader context: modern TCM forms part of overlapping care practices. MOH reported that nearly 40% of TCM users in the 2022 National Population Health Survey combined TCM and Western medicine for the same condition (Ministry of Health [MOH], 2025). This national finding helps contextualise the medicine hall's everyday role: buying products for nourishment or household care may be one part of a person's wider health routine.

6.2 How the shop brings TCM into everyday life

The themes form a connected account of access. Food gives herbs a household purpose, packs reduce selection and preparation effort, and packaging communicates uses. Local branding and manufacture connect products to Singapore's retail and regulatory setting. We interpret these features as practical means of bringing traditional materials into everyday use.

The mixed shop gives these activities one location. Branding connects the branch to a wider business, while Hougang's residential population gives context to the clientele described by staff. These features help explain the fit between its shelf range and household routines. The shop's everyday role emerges through products, preparation and place.

Unschuld's (2018) account of adaptation and Yang's (2022) history help frame these connections. Unschuld argues that Chinese medicine has always adapted to its social and political environment,

rather than remaining fixed as an unchanging "tradition". Yang shows that TCM in Singapore underwent a specific process of modernisation, institutionalisation and localisation, shaped by the state, medical professionals and religious organisations. These two perspectives help explain why the shop's retail practices are not simply commercial strategies, but part of a longer history of TCM adapting to local conditions. Our fieldwork extends this discussion into retail: traditional ingredients acquire practical household uses through familiar foods and prepared goods. Continuity becomes visible in how a neighbourhood shop arranges, explains and sells them.

7 Limitations

The report draws on one visit and one staff interview. Accounts of demand, preferences and cross-cultural purchases come from staff. Sales records, customer interviews and branch comparisons would deepen the assessment. Neighbourhood statistics describe the surrounding population, and industry accounts supply comparisons.

Complete soup recipes and sourcing and purchasing records were unavailable. The pictured Nature’s Green capsules have a confirmed Singapore manufacturing link; ingredient origins remain unknown, and staff named the category rather than the brand. Physician presence was unclear, and we recorded no consultation, prescription or patient outcome. MOH (2026) supplies the wider professional-registration context.

The appendix distinguishes reference profiles and external images from field photographs. Customer interviews and further visits could deepen this account.

8 Conclusion

Tong Keow makes TCM available through food, prepared products and a mixed medicine hall. Soup displays connect herbs to cooking and light nourishment. Prepared packs shift selection and portioning work to the seller, helping households begin with cooking. Local branding and manufacture place some goods within Singapore’s retail setting, while the mixed food range offers different communities familiar reasons to enter. Together, the displays and staff accounts support our argument that traditional materials gain everyday uses through adaptation.

The case brings continuity through adaptation into focus at the scale of a Hougang shop. Food use provides a household purpose, convenience changes the effort involved, and localisation gives products a recognisable form. These retail adaptations sustain opportunities for people across all races, religions and age groups to encounter TCM. Choosing treatment remains a separate task requiring assessment of the person’s pattern of signs and symptoms. The shop’s role in making products approachable and the clinical work of individual assessment are therefore distinct parts of the wider practice of care.

Appendix A Detailed fieldwork evidence

Appendix A retains the detailed survey findings from the group presentation. The tables identify staff-reported uses, traditional reference profiles and the sources of the photographs.

A1 Eight herb entries with separate reference profiles

The presentation groups ginseng and American ginseng in one entry. Table A1 separates their profiles, giving nine rows for the eight reported entries. The field cabinet also labels American ginseng separately.

Table A1 Traditional herb profiles in the eight presentation entries

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **人参** *Ren Shen* Ginseng (root) (PolyU, n.d.-h)	Sweet, slightly bitter; neutral	Heart, Spleen, Lung	Strongly tonifies original Qi; supports Spleen and Lung; generates fluids; calms the spirit.	Poor appetite, fatigue and breathlessness in Qi-deficiency patterns; thirst from fluid depletion.
 **西洋参** *Xi Yang Shen* American ginseng (root) (PolyU, n.d.-a)	Sweet, slightly bitter; cool	Heart, Lung, Kidney	Tonifies Qi and nourishes Yin; clears heat; generates fluids.	Fatigue, dry mouth, thirst and cough in Qi–Yin deficiency with deficiency heat.
 **党参** *Dang Shen* Codonopsis (root) (PolyU, n.d.-m)	Sweet; neutral	Spleen, Lung	Tonifies middle Qi; strengthens Spleen and Lung functions.	Poor appetite, loose stools, fatigue and shortness of breath in Spleen–Lung Qi deficiency.

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **黄芪** *Huang Qi* Astragalus / milkvetch (root) (PolyU, n.d.-l)	Sweet; warm	Spleen, Lung	Tonifies Qi; strengthens exterior defence; promotes fluid discharge and tissue repair.	Fatigue, poor appetite and loose stools in Qi deficiency; spontaneous sweating from weak exterior defence.
 **玉竹** *Yu Zhu* Fragrant Solomon's seal (rhizome) (PolyU, n.d.-g)	Sweet; slightly cold	Lung, Stomach	Nourishes Yin; moistens dryness; generates fluids and relieves thirst.	Dry cough, dry throat and thirst in Lung–Stomach Yin deficiency.
 **淮山 / 山药** *Huai Shan / Shan Yao* Chinese yam (rhizome) (PolyU, n.d.-f)	Sweet; neutral	Spleen, Lung, Kidney	Supports Spleen and Stomach; generates fluids and benefits Lung; strengthens Kidney.	Poor appetite and persistent diarrhoea in Spleen deficiency; chronic cough in Lung deficiency; frequent urination in Kidney deficiency.
 **红枣 / 大枣** *Hong Zao / Da Zao* Red dates / jujube (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-d)	Sweet; warm	Spleen, Stomach	Tonifies middle Qi; nourishes Blood; calms the spirit.	Poor appetite, tiredness and loose stools in Spleen-deficiency patterns.

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **枸杞子** *Gou Qi Zi* Goji / wolfberry (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-b)	Sweet; neutral	Liver, Kidney	Nourishes Liver and Kidney; replenishes essence; supports vision.	Dizziness, aching lower back and knees, and impaired vision in Liver–Kidney deficiency patterns.
 **罗汉果** *Luo Han Guo* Monk fruit (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Sweet; cool	Lung, Large Intestine	Clears heat; moistens Lung; lubricates the intestines.	Dry cough, sore throat and hoarseness in Lung-heat dryness; constipation from intestinal dryness.

Note. Herb photographs and traditional profiles are adapted from the Hong Kong Polytechnic University database (PolyU). Meridian names refer to TCM functional systems, and the applications describe traditional uses in their stated contexts.

A2 Eight reported product categories with illustrations

The eight categories follow presentation slide 4. The supplied photograph identifies Nature's Green Mind Soothe Capsules as the illustrated example for liver care and mood support. Details of mixtures and finished products are included where available in the field records.

Table A2 Illustrated profiles of the eight presentation product categories

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **Ginseng tonics** 人参 / 西洋参	Varies by formula.	Not recorded.	Staff linked use to fatigue, Qi support and immunity.	Staff described use for fatigue and general nourishment.
 **罗汉果** **Monk-fruit products** Reference material: monk fruit (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Reference fruit: sweet and cool.	Reference fruit: Lung and Large Intestine.	Staff associated it with throat comfort and cooling.	Fruit and drink forms were described, with recipes unrecorded.
 **花茶 / 凉茶** **Flower and herbal teas** Reference flower: chrysanthemum (PolyU, n.d.-e)	Mixture not recorded.	Mixture not recorded.	Staff described everyday wellness uses.	Staff linked simple brewing to younger buyers.
 **药材汤包** **Soup packs** Fieldwork soup display 13 September 2026	Complete recipe unknown.	Formula not recorded.	Presentation: light nourishment.	Preselected dried packs still require cooking.

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **灵芝保健品** **Lingzhi supplements** Reference: Lingzhi (PolyU, n.d.-i)	Supplement formula unknown.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff associated supplements with immunity support.	Staff described use for general wellness and immunity support.
 **养肝 / 疏肝解郁** Nature's Green 绿叶 Mind Soothe Capsules Supplied photograph	Formula not recorded.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff described Liver nourishment and soothing constraint; the box uses "Mind Soothe" language.	Staff linked this category to late nights and stress.
 **银翘类** **Yin Qiao-type remedies** Reference: honeysuckle (PolyU, n.d.-k)	Exact formula unidentified.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff associated this category with cold symptoms.	Staff described use for cold symptoms.
 **红花油 / 红油精** **Medicated oils** External example (Fei Fah, n.d.)	Topical formula unidentified.	No meridian assigned.	Staff associated oils with aches and injuries.	Staff described external use, including by older customers.

Note. Uses follow the interview or presentation. The Nature's Green box is a supplied product photograph; the other reference illustrations are identified in their rows. Complete product formulas were not recorded during the visit.

A3 Five locally linked examples and production status

Table A3 separates local cultivation, manufacture and packaging. Nature's Green is the brand of the pictured Mind Soothe Capsules. HSA lists the capsules as a Singapore-manufactured Chinese Proprietary Medicine (HSA, 2025b); their ingredient origins were not recorded.

Table A3 Locally linked examples retained from the presentation

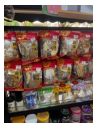
Example	Raw origin and grown in Singapore	Manufacture in Singapore	Processing packaging or brand link
 **Cactus 仙人掌** (NParks, n.d.-b)	Named as a possible locally grown example; origin of stock unknown	Not established	No specific product or producer identified.
 **Roselle 洛神花** (NParks, n.d.-a)	Named as a possible locally grown example; origin of stock unknown	Not established	No specific product or producer identified.
 **Mind Soothe Capsules 舒肝解郁胶囊** Nature's Green 绿叶 Finished CPM	Ingredient origins and Singapore cultivation are unverified.	HSA lists Tong Jum Chew as manufacturer and Singapore as the manufacturing country (HSA, 2025b).	Nature's Green is the brand of this finished Chinese Proprietary Medicine.
 **Five Flower Tea 五花茶** (Wing Joo Loong, n.d.)	Not established	Not established	Locally linked in the presentation; item-specific processor, packer and brand unknown.
 **Monk fruit tea 罗汉果茶** Reference: monk fruit (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Not established for the tea product	Not established	Locally linked in the presentation; item-specific processor, packer and brand unknown.

Note. NParks supplies the reference plant photographs. The cactus species and stock origins were not identified in the interview. The Five Flower Tea image is an external product example, and the monk-fruit image shows a reference ingredient. HSA supplies the manufacturing information for the Nature's Green capsules.

A4 Five soup therapies retained from the presentation

The five labels follow slide 6. Staff named Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates and goji as common soup ingredients. Table A4 records the named ingredients and the presentation's descriptions of nourishment and everyday care.

Table A4 Soup labels ingredients and reported purposes

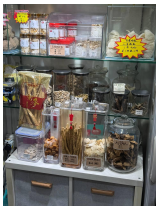
Soup label	Ingredients available from the record	Purpose and main use
 **Qing Bu Liang 清补凉** Field display context only	Complete recipe not recorded	Light nourishment and everyday care in the presentation.
 **Dang Shen and Huang Qi soup** **党参北芪补气汤** Named ingredients only	Dang Shen and Huang Qi are named; complete recipe unknown	Qi support and nourishment in the presentation.
 **Yu Zhu and Huai Shan soup** **玉竹淮山润燥汤** Named ingredients only	Yu Zhu and Huai Shan are named; complete recipe unknown	Moistening and nourishment in the presentation.
 **Goji and red date soup** **枸杞红枣养生汤** Named ingredients only	Goji and red dates are named; complete recipe unknown	Everyday nourishment and health maintenance.
 **Five Finger Fig soup** **五指毛桃健脾汤** Reference root only (DH, n.d.)	Five Finger Fig is named; other ingredients not recorded	Spleen and digestive support in traditional terms.

Note. Images show named materials, not complete formulas or finished soups. PolyU supplies Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, goji and red dates (n.d.-m, n.d.-l, n.d.-g, n.d.-f, n.d.-b, n.d.-d); Hong Kong's Department of Health (DH, n.d.) supplies Five Finger Fig root. The Qing Bu Liang image shows field display context only.

A5 Three comparatively lower-demand examples with illustrations

The lower-demand examples follow presentation slide 8: one named herb and two broader product categories. Their descriptions come from staff and the presentation, without a numerical sales ranking.

Table A5 Illustrated profiles of the lower-demand examples

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **半枝莲 Ban Zhi Lian** **Barbated skullcup herb** Reference material (PolyU, n.d.-c)	Sweet, bitter and cold.	Liver, Lung and Kidney.	Reference: clears heat and toxins, resolves stasis and promotes urination.	Reference uses include sores, throat swelling and oedema.
 **Specialist herbs** Requiring combinations	Varies by formula.	Varies by formula.	No combination was identified.	Staff described a need for preparation and guidance.
 **大补方** **Strong tonic formulas** Tonic material illustration only (PolyU, n.d.-h)	Formula not recorded.	Formula not recorded.	Presentation: intensive replenishment 大补.	The presentation associated lower appeal with suitability and climate.

Note. Ban Zhi Lian properties come from PolyU. The specialist-herb photograph shows the field cabinet, and the ginseng image illustrates a tonic material. Specific combination and tonic formulas were not recorded.

A6 Staff-described product uses without confirmed clinical prescriptions

Staff described the six product associations below, retained from slide 9. Physician presence at the outlet was unclear, and we recorded no clinical prescriptions or patient cases. Table A6 therefore presents the interview's retail descriptions.

Table A6 Staff-described product uses without confirmed clinical prescriptions

Complaint or wellness concern	Associated retail product	Clinical details not recorded
Colds	Yin Qiao type remedies	Formula and patient assessment not recorded.
Diarrhoea	Huoxiang Zhengqi type remedies	Formula and patient assessment not recorded.
Fatigue or Qi deficiency language	Ginseng or Dang Shen	Staff used fatigue and Qi-support language; no patient assessment recorded.
Perceived lower immunity	Lingzhi or supplements	Staff described immunity support; no patient assessment recorded.
Late nights stress and long work hours	Liver care or mood support products	Staff linked use to daily pressures; no diagnosis recorded.
Aches or injuries	Medicated oils	Staff described external use; no injury assessment recorded.

A7 Survey coverage and sources

Table A7 Survey coverage and details not recorded

Survey item	Record retained	Location	Details not recorded
A	Eight herb entries; nine reference profiles	A1; Section 3.1	No verified twelve-month sales ranking.
B	Eight product categories	A2; Section 4	Exact products and comparative sales unknown.
C	Five locally linked examples	A3; Section 5.1	Capsule manufacture corroborated; other origins unverified.
D	Five soup labels	A4; Section 3.2	Complete recipes and all pack identities unconfirmed.
E	One named herb and two categories	A5; Section 4.4	No verified bottom-three ranking.
F	No physician prescriptions recorded	A6; Section 7	Physician role not confirmed; no clinical cases recorded.
G	Six separate retail associations	A6; Section 6.1	No physician-treated cases recorded.

References

Accounting and Corporate Regulatory Authority. (n.d.). *ACRA information on corporate entities (T)* [Data set]. Data.gov.sg. Retrieved October 4, 2026, from https://data.gov.sg/datasets/d_72f37e5c5d192951ddc5513c2b134482/view

Amacha. (n.d.). *Amacha herbal milk tea* [Menu and brand website]. Retrieved October 4, 2026, from https://www.amacha.sg/

Angelynn T. (2026, January 5). *This S'pore biz is turning TCM into milk tea—8 mths in, it now has 3 outlets & sold 150K+ cups*. Vulcan Post. https://vulcanpost.com/907853/amacha-herbal-milk-tea/

Chin, S. F. (2024, May 26). Innovation amid tradition: How Chinatown merchants move with the times. *The Straits Times*. https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/innovation-amid-tradition-how-chinatown-merchants-move-with-the-times

Chua, V., Feng, C.-C., & Ho, E. L.-E. (2025). Ageing in networks: Living alone but connected. *Ageing & Society*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0144686X25100329

Department of Health, Hong Kong. (n.d.). *五指毛桃與斷腸草 [Five Finger Fig root and Gelsemium].* Chinese Medicine Regulatory Office. https://www.cmro.gov.hk/files/gcmti/research/mmi/ech_search/041_RF_vs_HGE_tc.pdf

Eu Yan Sang. (n.d.). *Shop halal products*. Retrieved October 4, 2026, from https://www.euyansang.com.sg/en/halal-2/

Fei Fah. (n.d.). *Red flower ointment 50 ml* [Product photograph]. Retrieved October 4, 2026, from https://feifah.com/zh/products/red-flower-ointment-50ml

Health Sciences Authority. (2025a, January). Guidelines on Chinese Proprietary Medicines product listing. https://file.go.gov.sg/hsa-cpm-listing-fsc-guidelines.pdf

Health Sciences Authority. (2025b). Listing of licensed Chinese Proprietary Medicine products [Data set; updated August 7, 2026]. data.gov.sg. Retrieved October 4, 2026, from https://data.gov.sg/datasets/d_2ae2e6beb458d059318c1c14ad899f98/view

Health Sciences Authority. (2026a, May 4). *Health supplement claims*. https://www.hsa.gov.sg/health-supplements/claims/

Health Sciences Authority. (2026b, April 6). *How Chinese Proprietary Medicines are regulated by HSA*. https://www.hsa.gov.sg/announcements/how-chinese-proprietary-medicines-are-regulated-by-hsa/

Health Sciences Authority. (2026c, March 13). *Overview of dealer's licences for Chinese Proprietary Medicines*. https://www.hsa.gov.sg/chinese-proprietary-medicines/manufacturing-import-wholesale/dealers-licence/overview/

Health Sciences Authority. (2026d, May 29). *Safety precautions when buying Chinese medicinal pills and capsules*. https://www.hsa.gov.sg/announcements/safety-precautions-when-buying-chinese-medicinal-pills-and-capsules/

Healthcare.com.sg. (n.d.). *Tong Keow Medical Hall (Hougang Central)*. Retrieved October 4, 2026, from https://www.healthcare.com.sg/item/tong-keow-medical-hall-hougang-central/

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-a). *American ginseng*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/american-ginseng

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-b). *Barbary wolfberry fruit*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/barbary-wolfberry-fruit

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-c). *Barbated skullcup herb*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/barbated-skullcup-herb

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-d). *Chinese date*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/chinese-date

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-e). *Chrysanthemum flower*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/chrysanthemum-flower

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-f). *Common yam rhizome*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/common-yam-rhizome

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-g). *Fragrant solomonseal rhizome*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/fragrant-solomonseal-rhizome

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-h). *Ginseng*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/ginseng

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-i). *Glossy Ganoderma*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/glossy-ganoderma

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-j). *Grosvenor momordica fruit*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/grosvenor-momordica-fruit

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-k). *Japanese honeysuckle flower*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/japanese-honeysuckle-flower

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-l). *Milkvetch root*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/milkvetch-root

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University. (n.d.-m). *Tangshen*. Chinese Herbal Medicine Database. https://herbaltcm.sn.polyu.edu.hk/herbal/tangshen

Housing & Development Board. (2024). *Key statistics: HDB annual report 2023/2024*. https://www.hdb.gov.sg/hdb-pulse/reports/annual-reports-and-financial-statements

Kumari, J. (2024, January 24). *68% of Singapore workers experience weekly stress at the workplace: Survey.* People Matters. https://sea.peoplemattersglobal.com/news/organisational-culture/68-of-singapore-workers-experience-weekly-stress-at-the-workplace-survey-40095

Lim, M. K., Sadarangani, P., Chan, H. L., & Heng, J. Y. (2005). Complementary and alternative medicine use in multiracial Singapore. *Complementary Therapies in Medicine, 13*(1), 16–24. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ctim.2004.11.002

Liu, Y., Yang, Q., & Hu, Y. (2026). Translation variations under legal constraints in the packaging information of traditional Chinese herbal medicine sold in Malaysia. *International Journal of Multilingualism, 23*(1), 973–1000. https://doi.org/10.1080/14790718.2025.2537184

Meteorological Service Singapore. (n.d.). *Climate of Singapore*. https://www.weather.gov.sg/climate-climate-of-singapore

Ministry of Health. (2025, July 6). *Speech by Mr Ong Ye Kung, Minister for Health, at the forum on the use of evidence-based Traditional Chinese Medicine in Western medicine practice*. https://www.moh.gov.sg/newsroom/speech-by-mr-ong-ye-kung--minister-for-health--at-the-forum-on-the-use-of-evidence-based-traditional-chinese-medicine-in-western-medicine-practice/

Ministry of Health. (2026, February 10). *About*. https://hpp.moh.gov.sg/tcm-practitioners/about/

Ministry of Manpower. (2026, February 3). *Written answer to PQ on moderating working hours*. https://www.mom.gov.sg/newsroom/parliament-questions-and-replies/2026/0203-written-answer-to-pq-on-moderating-working-hours

Nanyang Polytechnic. (n.d.). *From tradition to trend: NYP's collaborative journey with Heng Foh Tong in revolutionising herbal drinks*. https://www.nyp.edu.sg/industry/projects/revolutionise-herbal-drinks-heng-foh-tong

National Heritage Board. (n.d.). *Tou Mu Kung*. Roots. https://www.roots.gov.sg/places/places-landing/Places/national-monuments/tou-mu-kung

National Parks Board. (n.d.-a). *Hibiscus sabdariffa L.* Flora & Fauna Web. https://www.nparks.gov.sg/florafaunaweb/flora/2/0/2096

National Parks Board. (n.d.-b). *Opuntia cochenillifera.* Flora & Fauna Web. https://www.nparks.gov.sg/florafaunaweb/flora/2/2/2281

Singapore Department of Statistics. (n.d.). *Coverage of Singapore retail trade industry 2021* [SSIC 2020 codes]. https://www.singstat.gov.sg/-/media/files/find_data/industry/coverage-retail.pdf

Singapore Department of Statistics. (2024). *Resident population by planning area/subzone, age group and type of dwelling, June 2024* [Data set]. https://www.singstat.gov.sg/find-data/explore-data-themes/population/geographic-distribution/latest-news-data

Singapore Department of Statistics. (2025). *Resident population by planning area/subzone, age group and type of dwelling, June 2025* [Data set]. https://www.singstat.gov.sg/find-data/explore-data-themes/population/geographic-distribution/latest-news-data

Unschuld, P. U. (2018). *Traditional Chinese medicine: Heritage and adaptation* (B. Andrews, Trans.). Columbia University Press. https://cup.columbia.edu/book/traditional-chinese-medicine/9780231175012/

Unschuld, P. U., & Tessenow, H. (2011). *Huang Di nei jing su wen: An annotated translation of Huang Di's Inner Classic—Basic Questions* (Vol. 1). University of California Press.

Wing Joo Loong. (n.d.). *Lung soothing summer tea.* https://www.wjl.com.sg/products/wing-joo-loong-lung-soothing-summer-tea

World Health Organization. (2022). *WHO international standard terminologies on traditional Chinese medicine*. https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240042322

Yang, Y. (2022). A brief history of Chinese medicine in Singapore. In V. Lo & M. Stanley-Baker (Eds.), *Routledge handbook of Chinese medicine* (pp. 524–536). Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203740262-42

Appendix B Fieldwork photographs

Figure 1

Soup promotion in the neighbourhood retail setting



Note. Branded soup packs and a family cooking image at the shop frontage. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.

Figure 2

Preselected dried soup ingredients in branded packs



Note. Preselected dried ingredients in Tong Keow soup packs. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.

Figure 3

Herb labels and retail quality claims



Note. Cabinet labels for American ginseng and sulphur-free Dang Shen. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.